



SUNDAY MORNING · KITCHEN TABLE TRADITION

THE OFFICIAL FIREHALL RED LEAD RECIPE

A firehall breakfast staple passed down through generations.



Red Lead is the tomato sauce. In halls that still run a proper Sunday breakfast, the senior cook's cast iron carries a slow-simmered red sauce to the center of the table — not steak, not cracked eggs in the pan, and not a grab-and-go plate.

Firefighters make it because the sauce anchors a full spread: bacon, sausage, eggs, toast, hash browns, and orange juice served alongside while the crew actually sits down together. This card is the sauce recipe only.

Prep

10 min

Simmer

35 min

Best pan

12-inch cast iron



INGREDIENTS

Tomato Red Lead sauce — scale for your crew. Cook bacon, sausage, eggs, toast, and potatoes separately.

SERVES 4

- **1 can (28 oz)** crushed tomatoes
- **1/2 cup** tomato juice
- **1/2 large** yellow onion (diced)
- **2 tbsp** butter
- **1 tsp** kosher salt
- **1/2 tsp** black pepper

SERVES 8

- **2 cans (28 oz each)** crushed tomatoes
- **1 cup** tomato juice (or use liquid from one can if thick)
- **1 large** yellow onion (diced small)
- **4 tbsp** butter
- **2 tsp** kosher salt
- **1 tsp** black pepper (freshly ground)

SERVES 12

- **3 cans (28 oz each)** crushed tomatoes
- **1 1/2 cups** tomato juice
- **2 large** yellow onion (diced)
- **6 tbsp** butter
- **1 tbsp** kosher salt
- **1 1/2 tsp** black pepper

Audit note: Traditional Red Lead is crushed tomatoes, onion, butter, salt, and pepper simmered in cast iron until thick. Optional garlic, sugar, or hot sauce match your hall — never steak or eggs in this pan.



HOW TO COOK RED LEAD SAUCE

Beginner-friendly hall workflow — read once before you touch the range.

1 START THE REST OF BREAKFAST BEFORE THE SAUCE

Red Lead is the tomato pan — not the whole meal. Put bacon in the oven, sausage links on a sheet pan, coffee on, and toast ready before you dice the onion. The sauce needs a calm simmer, not a rushed boil while the crew is still hunting for plates.

Timing: 5 min setup

Common mistake: Starting the sauce first and letting it scorch while you scramble to cook everything else.

2 MELT BUTTER AND SWEAT THE ONION

Set a 12-inch cast iron over medium heat. Melt the butter until it foams and smells nutty — not brown. Add the diced onion (and bell pepper if your hall uses it). Stir every minute or so until the onion turns soft and translucent with light gold at the edges.

Timing: 8–10 min

Visual cue: Onion pieces bend easily on the spoon; no raw white centers.

Common mistake: Cranking heat to “speed it up” — butter burns and the sauce tastes bitter.

3 ADD GARLIC, THEN TOMATOES

If using garlic, stir it in for 45 seconds until fragrant — not brown. Pour in crushed tomatoes, tomato juice, tomato paste if your hall adds a spoon for body, salt, and pepper. Stir until the red is even and the pan looks like thick soup.

Timing: 2 min

Visual cue: Uniform deep red; no dry tomato paste streaks.

4 SIMMER UNTIL THE SAUCE THICKENS

Drop heat to medium-low. Simmer with the pan uncovered, stirring every few minutes so the bottom does not stick. The sauce is ready when it coats a spoon and a drag through the middle leaves a brief trail that slowly fills in.

Timing: 25–35 min

Visual cue: Thick enough to mound slightly on toast; raw tomato smell is gone.

Common mistake: Covering too early — steam keeps it watery. Uncovered simmer builds body.

5 TASTE, ADJUST, AND HOLD

Taste for salt and pepper. Add the pinch of sugar only if the tomatoes are sharp. For service, hold the pan on the lowest steady heat or transfer to a warm oven (170°F / 75°C) with foil on top. Sauce should stay above 140°F (60°C) for food safety.

Timing: 2 min

Visual cue: Balanced savory tomato — not flat, not candy-sweet.

6

CARRY THE PAN TO THE TABLE

Place the cast iron in the center of the spread. Bacon, sausage, eggs, toast, hash browns, and juice stay in their own platters. The crew serves themselves from the Red Lead pan with a spoon while everything else passes around it.

Timing: Serve immediately

Common mistake: Plating Red Lead to-go — it is hall table food, meant to be shared from the pan.



TRADITIONAL FIREHALL BREAKFAST

Red Lead is almost never eaten on its own. It is one proud pan in a large Sunday-style spread — the breakfast is as much about crew camaraderie as it is about the food.



Red Lead sauce — center of the table.



Sides served separately around the sauce.

BACON

Sheet-pan at 400°F (205°C) until crisp; refill the platter.

EGGS

Scrambled in a hotel pan or fried to order — separate from the sauce.

HASH BROWNS OR POTATOES

On the griddle or oven — not mixed into the Red Lead pan.

BREAKFAST SAUSAGE

Links in the oven or bulk crumbled on the griddle.

TOAST

Thick bread, butter and jam on the table.

ORANGE JUICE

Pitcher on the table; refill without being asked.

Station workflow: One cook on the Red Lead sauce, others on bacon, sausage, eggs, toast, and coffee. Carry the cast iron last — when chairs are pulled up and the crew can stay at the table.



FIREHALL TIPS

MAKE IT AHEAD

Simmer the sauce the night before, cool quickly, and refrigerate. Reheat in cast iron over medium-low with a splash of tomato juice — stir until glossy again. Do not microwave the whole pan if you can avoid it.

SCALE FOR THE CREW

Use the 4 / 8 / 12 scaling on page 2. For two pans, split onion and tomato evenly — never double depth in one skillet or the center stays cold while the edges scorch.

HOLDING TEMPERATURE

Hold at 140°F (60°C) or above on the range's lowest flame or in a 170°F (75°C) oven. Stir before service. If the sauce skin over, fold it back in — do not scrape burnt pan bottom into the sauce.

BEST CAST IRON

A well-seasoned 12-inch skillet is the standard. Larger crews use two pans or a 15-inch lodge — same technique, more surface for evaporation.

ROOKIE MISTAKES

Boiling hard (splits the tomato and makes it grainy), under-salting until the table adds hot sauce, and confusing Red Lead with the steak skillet some halls also call by the same name — this card is tomato sauce only.

Print this card and tape it inside the kitchen cupboard. When the tones are quiet on a Sunday morning, you will know exactly how to run the sauce — and why the table matters more than the timer.

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